

which they packed with 230 kegs of gunpowder, totaling four tons of charge, sandbagged to direct the force upward. The miners retraced their steps, unwinding a 98-ft (30-m) fuse. The plan was to break the enemy line in an instant, then exploit the breach with waves of assault troops who would pour through the punctured works and roll up the Confederate army.

At 4:45 a.m., on July 30, Elliott's Salient erupted in an earthshaking roar, a blast that carried skyward men, cannons, gun carriages, and tons of earth. When the dust had cleared, the Salient was gone, replaced by a 170-ft (52-m) long crater, nearly 80ft (24m) wide and 30ft (9m) deep. The assault troops clambered out of their trenches, reached the edge of the crater, then halted, stupefied at the sight of shattered men and guns strewn across its bottom. Other troops managed to get around it, but since their leaders had remained behind, they quickly became disorganized. In the ensuing chaos, the Confederates recovered enough to mount counterattacks, and the Battle of the Crater, as it would be called, degenerated into a savage struggle. Screaming men pounded each other, amid cries of "No quarter!" Black Union troops, trapped in the crater, were shot down even after surrendering. One Southerner later recalled with horror: "My heart sickened at the deeds I saw done." Those Union survivors who had not been captured fled back to their own lines. Grant admitted that it was "the saddest affair I witnessed in the war."